

Teaching Philosophy

As a teacher and student who has experienced both teacher-centered and student-centered language teaching and learning, I firmly believe that language is acquired more efficiently through social activities by using meaningful communications. In this way, creating a small community in a class and having students actively involved in it is a general guide for me when teaching English as a second language (ESL). Therefore, from my perspective, language learning takes place more naturally when students use it as a tool to convey meaning. By putting students as the primary focus in each class, I am responsible for creating such an environment for my students and facilitating their participation. The following principles may better explain what I believe effective learning and teaching are.

A safe, respectful, and positive learning environment

In my classroom, I want my students to bravely speak up if they have different ideas, and I am always sending a message that teachers are also learners and they make mistakes. In this way, I hope students treat me more like a learning partner who also wants to make progress. In another aspect, students do not worry about making mistakes in the class because they see the classroom as a learning space in which mistakes are used to check their learning progress, but not a place to perform perfectly in English proficiency. And I will provide corrective feedback in different ways according to different situations. For example, I usually do recast for students who might be aware of their mistakes, and explicit corrective feedback for mistakes which are harder to be realized. More frequently, I make elicitation to induce students' self-correction because it is a good way to avoid repeated mistakes.

Sometimes peers are the best teachers because they know what it is like to not understand. Therefore, they may have more understandable explanations. I would ask peers to help students first when they have some questions or meet learning difficulties. And I give plenty of opportunities for students to interact with each other through pair/group activities. For example, we do information-gap and opinion-gap activities in groups to complete real life tasks in order to learn different language forms, and we do peer reviews for writing. Students work cohesively and help each other out when needed. Moreover, it is worth mentioning that every student's contribution to the class is necessary and significant, and no one is left behind.

Needs analysis

Each student should know that every single part of their background is respected. And it is the teacher's responsibility to know students' backgrounds and do need analyses. Then, teaching should be designed to fulfill students' needs. In this way, teaching might be different for different groups of students because they might have different needs and goals even though they are at the same level or using the same textbook.

Communicative Language Teaching (CLT)

The communicative language teaching (CLT) approach integrates reading, listening, writing, and speaking. Seeing language as a tool for communication, I believe CLT is a good approach which

emphasizes the interaction as the medium as well as the ultimate goal of language study. “Real-life circumstances” is what a teacher wants to bring to the class, which means that we should make each activity close to students’ lives and let the class be student-centered. For example, role plays, information gap activity, and game. All these activities should be conducted to maximize and prioritize small group discussions.

Then, an activity should be divided into three steps: pre-, during-, and post-stage. Pre-stage is to prepare for learning with the most teacher-talk. Teachers will help set up the context and lead students to the topic as well as raise student’s interests. For the during-stage, a new language focus should be practiced through an authentic and communicative activity. Typically, students are told to achieve a goal or complete a task through a speaking activity in small groups. For example, students may be asked to work in groups to make a campaign based on different city problems, it can be ‘too much pollution’ or ‘too little public transportation’ as long as the expression of quantity is largely practiced through group communications and the campaign is being made. For the post-stage, we mainly work on the review and reflection of the during-stage, a similar activity could be done, or teachers may ask different questions for students to recall and reflect on the work achieved so far. In all these steps, teachers play an important role in promoting the task being efficiently and successfully accomplished. Enough anchoring, clear instructions, appropriate corrective feedback, good scaffolding, and smooth transitions among each stage are things I believe a good ESL teacher should work on and make sure to include in every single activity.